highexplosive bombs. Among the prisoners who died are the former Reichstag deputies Breitscheid and Thälmann.

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In the course of time, Thälmann's death would provide German communists with a martyr – a man cast as a pivotal historical figure: a myth and legend in propaganda. But that was all in the future.

As autumn of 1944 progressed into winter, the Allies pushed as far as the Rhine. Despite his best efforts, Hitler's Ardennes offensive failed, leaving German military reserves exhausted. In January 1945, the vastly superior Soviet army pushed over the Vistula bridgeheads, overrunning Germany's eastern provinces. By the end of the month, Stalin's men were digging into positions in Küstrin and Frankfurt an der Oder, near the German-Polish border. As this was happening, Anglo-American pilots continued to unload bombs on Berlin, Dresden and many other German cities. However, as the country rapidly disintegrated, there was no sign whatever of revolt, as the power and omniscience of the police kept the regime firmly at the rudder. The Führer himself – joined by senior aides – assumed residence in a bunker underneath his once-majestic Chancellery, which resembled a jumble of collapsed walls and crushed interiors. Fearful of losing grip on power, authorities cracked down on defeatism and potential threats. Believing his life in danger, Honecker took advantage of lax security when working at the juvenile women's prison on Magdalene Straße. Just after 11 am on 6 March 1945, along with former KPD activist and fellow inmate Erich Hanke, wearing filthy prison garb and carrying bricklayer's buckets, Honecker clambered over a lightning rod to a neighbouring house, navigated a maze of landings and walked out to freedom on Alfred Straße. For all their eagerness, however, the men stepped into the full horror of wartime Berlin, as Honecker reflected in his memoirs.